

THE STONE AGE — PALAEOLITHIC AND MESOLITHIC

INDIAN PREHISTORY: TECHNOLOGY • LANDSCAPES • LIFEWAYS • EVIDENCE LIMITS

Core first • regional chronology • no tool=people equation • qualified transition

1

MASTER QUESTION AND EVIDENCE RULE

- EVIDENCE** How can text-free deep time become evidence-based history?
- MECHANISM** LITHICS + STRATIGRAPHY + DATES + FAUNA/FLORA + BODIES + ART + LANDSCAPE
- LIMIT** OBSERVE -> ASSOCIATE -> DATE -> INTERPRET -> QUALIFY
- VERDICT** Verdict: material abundance permits history, but confidence varies by context.

ANSWER LINE: Evidence becomes history only through context and qualification.

2

CHRONOLOGY WITHOUT A PAN-INDIAN LADDER

- EVIDENCE** Lower Palaeolithic -> Middle Palaeolithic -> Upper Palaeolithic -> Mesolithic
- MECHANISM** bifaces/core-flake -> prepared flakes -> blades/burins -> microlithic composites
- LIMIT** MACRO PHASE -> REGIONAL SEQUENCE -> DATED STRATUM -> ASSEMBLAGE
- VERDICT** Transitions overlap; phase labels are neither races nor universal dates.

ANSWER LINE: Broad phases guide; regional sequences decide.

3

PLEISTOCENE-HOLOCENE AND DATING

- EVIDENCE** Climate/river/sea-level change -> resources shift -> human choices change
- MECHANISM** Stratigraphy = relative order | radiocarbon = suitable organics
- LIMIT** Luminescence = mineral exposure event | typology = comparison, not sole date
- VERDICT** A date belongs first to the sampled event; redeposition and error matter.

ANSWER LINE: Date the event, then argue the association.

4

LITHIC OPERATIONAL CHAIN

- EVIDENCE** RAW STONE -> CORE -> FLAKE/BLADE -> RETOUCH/BACKING -> HAFT/USE -> DISCARD

4

LITHIC OPERATIONAL CHAIN

- EVIDENCE** RAW STONE -> CORE -> FLAKE/BLADE -> RETOUCH/BACKING -> HAFT/USE -> DISCARD
- MECHANISM** Read cortex, hammerstones, rough-outs, debitage, wear, residues and spacing.
- LIMIT** Primary context preserves activity relation; secondary context is displaced.
- VERDICT** Tool form suggests function; assemblage and use evidence test it.

ANSWER LINE: Read the reduction chain, not only the finished tool.

5

LOWER PALAEOLITHIC AND ACHEULIAN

- EVIDENCE** Acheulian = assemblage marked by bifacial handaxes and cleavers.
- MECHANISM** Also retain choppers, flakes, cores, hammerstones and resharpening debris.
- LIMIT** Soanian/Madrasian cannot be treated as sealed races or civilisations.
- VERDICT** Technology records learned choices, not one hominin species.

ANSWER LINE: Acheulian is technology, never a race.

6

REGIONAL LOWER PALAEOLITHIC LANDSCAPES

- EVIDENCE** Soan-Siwalik: terrace lithics + fluvial caution
- MECHANISM** Attirampakkam: deep Acheulian -> early regional Middle Palaeolithic transition
- LIMIT** Hunsgi-Baichbal/Isampur: water + quarry + manufacture + habitation
- VERDICT** Bhimbetka/Narmada/Son/Belan: recurrent corridors with different contexts.

ANSWER LINE: Indian sequences are landscapes, not isolated type-sites.

7

NARMADA HOMININ CONTROL

- EVIDENCE** 1982 Arun Sonakia -> Hathnora cranial fragment in Narmada gravel context
- MECHANISM** Associated fauna and nearby late Acheulian tools; later central-valley finds
- LIMIT** Competing labels: advanced Homo erectus / archaic Homo sapiens / intermediate
- VERDICT** Safe claim: rare archaic hominin evidence; age, taxon and authorship debated.

ANSWER LINE: Hathnora is decisive evidence with unresolved classification.

ANSWER LINE: Hathnora is decisive evidence with unresolved classification.

MIDDLE PALAEOLITHIC

- EVIDENCE** Flakes + scrapers + points + borers; older bifaces may continue.
- MECHANISM** LEVALLOIS: shape convexities -> prepare platform -> detach planned flake
- LIMIT** Attirampakkam, Nevasa, Didwana and Son-Belan show regional sequences.
- VERDICT** Levallois is a method, not a finished tool or biological population.

ANSWER LINE: Prepared-core planning changed production without total replacement.

UPPER PALAEOLITHIC

- EVIDENCE** Parallel-sided blades + burins + some bone tools
- MECHANISM** Kurnool caves: organic tools/fauna | Patne/Bhimbetka: eggshell ornaments
- LIMIT** Ochre, beads and special objects widen evidence for communication.
- VERDICT** Symbolism is supportable; exact ritual, deity or social code is not.

ANSWER LINE: Symbolic evidence broadens history but does not decode belief.

LIFEWAYS AND INFERENCE LIMITS

- EVIDENCE** Plants + game + fish + turtles + shellfish -> broad flexible subsistence
- MECHANISM** Quarry -> task camp -> recurrent camp -> shelter = linked settlement system
- LIMIT** Fire/hearth claims require anthropogenic burning in secure context.
- VERDICT** Sharing and learning are plausible; rank and gender need independent evidence.

ANSWER LINE: Mobility was organised; social institutions remain partly hidden.

MESOLITHIC TECHNOLOGY AND RESIDENCE

- EVIDENCE** Fine stone -> bladelet -> backed/geometric microlith -> composite implement
- MECHANISM** Broad-spectrum niches -> processing/storage -> varied residence
- LIMIT** Microliths can pre-date the Holocene and continue with food production.
- VERDICT** Semi-sedentism needs a bundle: deposits, huts, hearths, seasonality, burials.

12

- MECHANISM** Broad-spectrum niches -> processing/storage -> varied residence
- LIMIT** Microliths can pre-date the Holocene and continue with food production.
- VERDICT** Semi-sedentism needs a bundle: deposits, huts, hearths, seasonality, burials.

ANSWER LINE: Mesolithic change combined composite tools and varied residence.

MESOLITHIC REGIONAL MAP

- EVIDENCE** Bagor: long sequence + disputed domesticates | Langhnaj: burials/wild fauna
- MECHANISM** Adamgarh: long sequence; date/stratigraphy caution | Bhimbetka: layered art
- LIMIT** Sarai Nahar Rai/Mahadaha/Damdama: wetlands + burials + longer residence
- VERDICT** Chopani Mando: huts/grinding/wild rice | Baghor II: microlith manufacture.

ANSWER LINE: Shared microliths did not erase regional economies.

13

BURIALS, ROCK ART AND TRANSITION

- EVIDENCE** Burial -> treatment/memory; belief, kinship and hierarchy need patterns.
- MECHANISM** Bhimbetka superimposition -> relative order; paintings span several periods.
- LIMIT** Grinding/pottery/wild rice -> processing/use, not automatic cultivation.
- VERDICT** Foraging, management, herding and cultivation overlapped regionally.

ANSWER LINE: Burial, art and food-production claims need inference ladders.

14

UPSC EXECUTION AND QUALIFIED VERDICT

- EVIDENCE** PRELIMS: period + region + technology + certainty; eliminate category errors.
- MECHANISM** 2019 Denisovan: archaic human population; no Indian fossil claim follows.
- LIMIT** MAINS: claim -> named site/assemblage -> analysis -> qualification -> comparison.
- VERDICT** VERDICT: Indian prehistory is a regional mosaic, not a teleological ladder.

ANSWER LINE: Map phase to tool, site to evidence and every claim to its limit.

QUALIFIED VERDICT: A REGIONAL MOSAIC OF CONTINUITY AND INNOVATION, RECONSTRUCTED FROM UNEVEN MATERIAL EVIDENCE.